

A WhatsApp account today holds far more than conversations; it acts as a gateway to digital banking alerts, personal data, and financial transactions. With over 500 million users in India, the platform has become a prime target for cybercriminals using a sophisticated method known as ghost pairing.

This attack allows hackers to access a user's WhatsApp account without physically touching the phone. Recognising the growing risk, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) has issued an advisory warning citizens about this emerging threat. As WhatsApp payments and banking notifications become deeply embedded in daily life, understanding ghost pairing is critical, not just to protect messages, but to secure one's entire financial ecosystem.

What Is Ghost Pairing?

Ghost pairing is a sophisticated cyberattack in which hackers gain unauthorised access to a WhatsApp account by misusing the platform's multi-device feature. Instead of installing malware or stealing passwords, attackers exploit legitimate WhatsApp functionality created for user convenience, making the attack harder to detect.

The method relies on WhatsApp Web or linked devices, which normally lets users access their account on up to four devices. Cybercriminals manipulate this feature by tricking users into scanning malicious QR codes or sharing verification codes, silently linking the victim's account to the attacker's device. The pairing happens without obvious signs, earning the name ghost pairing.

According to cybersecurity experts at CERT-In (Indian Computer Emergency Response Team), ghost pairing incidents have increased, with financial fraud being the primary motive in 65% of reported cases.

How Does Ghost Pairing Work on WhatsApp?

The ghost pairing attack unfolds through these steps:

Step 1: Initial Contact

Attackers begin with phishing emails, SMS messages, or phone calls, often posing as banks, government bodies, or WhatsApp support. The communication is designed to create urgency, claiming an account verification issue or promising exclusive rewards, to lower the recipient's guard.

Step 2: QR Code Deception

The attacker sends a QR code, disguised as a verification requirement or security update. This QR code is actually a WhatsApp Web linking code generated from the hacker's device. When scanned, it unknowingly pairs the attacker's device with the victim's account.

Step 3: Silent Access

Once paired, the hacker gains complete access to the WhatsApp conversations, contacts,

and media files. They can read messages, send texts on the user's behalf, and access any financial information shared through the platform, all while the user remains unaware.

Step 4: Financial Exploitation

With access secured, criminals target banking communications, UPI transactions, and one-time passwords (OTPs). They may request money from the user's contacts, intercept banking OTPs, or gather sensitive financial data for identity theft.

Why Is Ghost Pairing Dangerous?

Ghost pairing exposes WhatsApp users to multiple layers of risk, impacting both finances and personal well-being. The dangers extend well beyond compromised chats.

- **Financial Fraud:** Hackers can intercept banking alerts and OTPs received on WhatsApp, enabling unauthorised transactions. They may also impersonate the account holder to request money from contacts, exploiting long-standing trust.
- **Identity Theft:** WhatsApp conversations often contain sensitive details such as Aadhaar numbers, PAN information, and bank details. Cybercriminals compile this data to create synthetic identities, which are then used for loan applications, credit card fraud, or other financial crimes.
- **Loss of Privacy:** Once access is gained, attackers can read private conversations, view shared media, and monitor ongoing chats—often without the victim realising it immediately.
- **Psychological Impact:** Victims frequently experience stress, anxiety, and trust issues after discovering that their personal conversations and relationships have been compromised.

These combined risks make ghost pairing a serious and often underestimated cyber threat.

Signs an Account May Be Compromised

Recognising ghost pairing at an early stage can significantly limit damage. Users are advised to stay alert for the following warning signs:

- **Unexpected WhatsApp Web Sessions:** Regularly checking Settings > Linked Devices is essential. The presence of unfamiliar devices or locations strongly suggests unauthorised access.
- **Message Read Receipts:** Messages showing as *read* despite not being opened can indicate another linked device viewing conversations.
- **Unusual Battery Drain:** Sudden or unexplained battery consumption may occur when the account is active on multiple devices simultaneously.

- **Contact Complaints:** Friends or family reporting unusual messages or money requests sent from the account should be treated as a red flag.
- **Missing Messages:** Conversations disappearing or messages being deleted without user action may signal external control.

If any combination of these signs appears, immediate action is critical. Logging out of all devices via **Settings > Linked Devices > Log out from all devices** can help contain further compromise.

Impact on WhatsApp Banking and Financial Transactions

The growing integration of WhatsApp with banking services significantly amplifies the risks associated with ghost pairing. Many Indian banks now use WhatsApp to send transaction alerts, account statements, and UPI-related updates, turning everyday convenience into a potential security vulnerability if unauthorised access occurs.

Consider a common scenario: a user receives a [credit card](#) statement via WhatsApp. If ghost pairing is active, an attacker can silently intercept this data, gaining insights into card details, spending behaviour, and credit limits. Such information is often used for targeted phishing attacks or traded on dark web marketplaces. To counter these risks, banks have implemented strong digital security frameworks, including [multi-factor authentication](#) and encrypted communication, to protect customers across digital touchpoints.

UPI integration presents additional exposure. Attackers may send fraudulent payment requests to contacts, leveraging personal trust, or manipulate saved beneficiary details to divert refunds and cashback, making financial vigilance essential.

Preventive Measures to Stay Safe

Staying protected from ghost pairing requires consistent vigilance and a few proactive security habits. When followed regularly, these steps significantly reduce the risk of unauthorised access.

- **Enable Two-Step Verification**
Users should navigate to *Settings > Account > Two-step verification* and set a six-digit PIN. This extra layer ensures that even if a hacker gains access to the phone number, the WhatsApp account remains protected without the PIN.
- **Conduct Regular Device Audits**
WhatsApp allows users to view all linked devices, including device type, location, and last active time. Checking this section weekly helps identify and remove any unfamiliar devices immediately.
- **Exercise QR Code Caution**
Scanning QR codes from unknown or unsolicited sources should be avoided. Legitimate banks, government bodies, or WhatsApp support do not ask users to scan

QR codes for verification. When in doubt, users should contact the organisation through official channels.

- **Enable Security Notifications**

Turning on *Security notifications* under *Settings > Account* ensures alerts are received whenever someone attempts to register the account on a new device.

- **Keep the App Updated**

Regular WhatsApp updates include critical security patches that address emerging vulnerabilities, making timely updates essential for account safety.

What to Do If One Is a Victim of Ghost Pairing

Swift action can significantly limit damage if a WhatsApp account has been compromised through ghost pairing. Cybersecurity experts stress the importance of responding immediately and systematically.

- **Disconnect All Linked Devices Immediately**

The first step is to go to *Settings > Linked Devices* and log out of all devices. This action instantly cuts off the attacker's access.

- **Secure Banking and Financial Accounts**

If any financial details were shared on WhatsApp, the affected user should contact their bank without delay. Requesting a temporary block on digital transactions and resetting internet banking credentials helps prevent unauthorised transfers.

- **Report the Incident Officially**

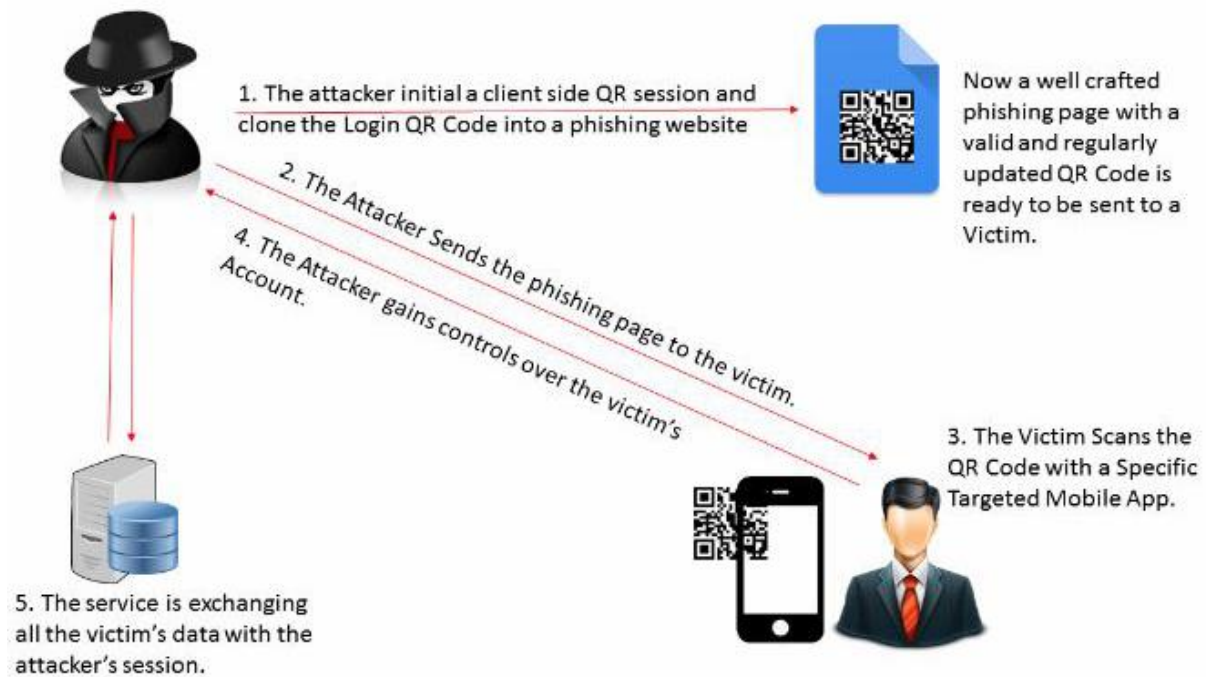
A cybercrime complaint should be filed at *gov.in* or by calling the national cybercrime helpline *1930*. Screenshots and message logs should be preserved as evidence.

- **Alert Contacts Proactively**

Informing friends, family, and colleagues about the compromise helps prevent impersonation scams and further financial losses.

Final Words

Ghost pairing is a serious cyber threat, but awareness and timely action can prevent major risks. By understanding how such attacks work, spotting early warning signs, and using security features like two-step verification and device monitoring, users can protect their WhatsApp accounts and financial data. Staying informed and alert is key to digital safety.



Want to perform the attack ?

Go to this path in the shared Github Repository - [/QRLJacking/](#)
and execute *QrlJacker.py*

Keep following Breached for more Attacks and Cybersecu4rity Tutorials.